

ANI

TO THE PEOPLE
Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami (centre) with BJP candidate Anil Baluni in Chamoli, Pauri-Garhwal

ex-Congress CM Harish Rawat's son Virendra. BJP national spokesperson Anil Baluni is replacing former CM Tirath Singh Rawat in Pauri-Garhwal, and will take on former state Congress chief Ganesh Godiyal. In Tehri-Garhwal, the BJP has re-nominated the titular queen of the erstwhile kingdom, Mala Rajya Laxmi Shah, who will face Congress's Jot Singh Gunsola. Union minister Ajay Bhatt is up against Rahul Gandhi loyalist Prakash Joshi at Nainital-Udham Singh Nagar. In Almora, BJP's Ajay Tamta will face old rival Pradeep Tamta of the Congress.

The Congress faces a tough challenge in Haridwar and Nainital, where Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party has fielded former UP legislator Maulana Jamil Ahmad Qasmi and Akhtar Ali respectively. The BSP commands a 14-15 per cent vote share of Muslims and Dalits in both seats. With clashes erupting in Haldwani (Nainital) this February following the demolition of an allegedly unauthorised madrasa and mosque, the BJP and the Congress are trying to establish their credentials. "In an intense battle, social groups see who is in a better position to win.... They don't want to end up as vote-splitters and help their rivals," says former CM Harish Rawat.

In Pauri Garhwal district, the BJP is haunted by the brutal killing of 19-year-old Ankita Bhandari, a receptionist at a Rishikesh resort, in September 2022 and widespread allegations against the state administration of hushing the matter up. Though prime suspect and resort owner Pulkit Arya, son of BJP leader Vinod Arya, did confess to the murder and Vinod was expelled from the party, Ankita's family alleges that the government is trying to shield an important partyman. The Congress's Godiyal is giving the issue the widest publicity. However, Dhami tells INDIA TODAY, "She was our daughter, our sister; I have a moral and constitutional responsibility to ensure she gets justice."

In Garhwal and Kumaon districts, where people have a long tradition of serving in the armed forces, the Congress has raised the Centre's short-term Agnipath recruitment scheme—under which youths are recruited for four years, with only 25 per cent retained for 15 more years—and promised to scrap it if they come to power. With no guarantee of fixed employment, the scheme was greeted with huge protests in Uttarakhand when it was announced in 2022.

The Congress is also raising the issue of ecological damage wrought by the Char Dham projects, highlighting the Silkyara-Barkot tunnel collapse last November. The party has a heavy arsenal, but how effective it is against the BJP will play out in the battle on April 19. ■

WEST BENGAL

KURMIS TAKE A STAND

Unhappy with the state and Centre for not granting them ST status, the community will fight independently in several seats they helped the BJP win in 2019

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Disillusioned by the "false promises" of the Union and state governments to grant them Scheduled Tribe (ST) status, the Kurmi community has decided to field its own candidates in West Bengal for the impending Lok Sabha election. Their dominant presence in the four districts of Paschim Medinipur, Purulia, Jhargram and Bankura—collectively known as Jangalmahal—make them a deciding or important factor in polls. If they constitute 65 per cent of the population in Purulia, they are 42 per cent, 17 per cent and 18 per cent in Jhargram, Paschim Medinipur and Bankura, respectively. The decision is significant because members of the community voted en masse for the BJP in the 2019 general election, helping it sweep the Bankura, Bishnupur, Jhargram, Medinipur and Purulia seats for the first time, contributing significantly to the party's tally of 18 out of the state's 42 seats, and cementing its



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

MAIN POINT
Adivasi Kurmi Samaj chief Ajit Kumar Mahato